would require some time. And since there had never been women pilot officers in the station, the infrastructure required for women was missing as well. There were no separate changing rooms at the airstrip, so a makeshift changing room was made for the two of us using steel cupboards as a partition. One of us would stand guard while the other would change, and this happened for some time until a separate changing room was built. After about two months, I got my own blue LML Vespa. By then, the other officers had become familiar with our presence and that awkward feeling that we had sensed initially had abated.

I was often sent to ferry helicopters from the Srinagar airbase, where our unit's permanent detachment was also established. During the next two and a half years, a sense of acceptance could now be felt among other male officers of the station, and we spent a good time there. In those two years, Dada cleared his SSB, went for military training and got commissioned into the Indian Army as a second lieutenant. He began serving with a battalion of the Gorkha Rifles. Both Papaji's children were now commissioned officers.

During the same time, in 1998, India and Pakistan conducted nuclear tests, which led to an increasingly tense situation between the two countries. As a consequence, in the winter of 1998–1999, Pakistani armed forces started to send covertly trained troops of regular and paramilitary forces, allegedly in the guise of mujahideen, into Indian territory across the Line of Control (LoC). This infiltration, code-named 'Operation Badr', was aimed at severing the link between Kashmir and Ladakh, which would have caused Indian forces to withdraw from the Siachen glacier. Pakistan felt this could lead to negotiations with respect to the Kashmir dispute. But since there were no Indian troops deployed at winter-vacated posts on the Indian side, India was not aware about this infiltration. It was only on 3 May that India came to know about this, when local shepherds reported movement of Pakistani troops in the Kargil region, which was located between Kashmir and Ladakh. To confirm this, a patrol of Indian Army soldiers was sent to the hills in Kargil. The capture of five Indian soldiers, who were tortured to death, followed by heavy artillery shelling by the Pakistan Army on the